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AI



Meta built its AI
reputation on openness
— that may be changing

Top members of [Meta's new Superintelligence Lab](#) discussed pivoting away from the company's powerful open source AI model, Behemoth, and instead developing a closed model, [reports The New York Times](#).

Sources told The Times that Meta had completed training on Behemoth, but delayed its release due to underwhelming internal performance. When the new Superintelligence Lab launched, testing on the model reportedly halted.

The discussions are just that — discussions. Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg would still need to sign off on any changes, and a company spokesperson told TechCrunch that Meta's position on open source AI is "unchanged."

"We plan to continue releasing leading open source models," the spokesperson said. "We haven't released everything we've developed historically and we expect to continue training a mix of open and closed models going forward."

The spokesperson did not comment on Meta's potential shift away from Behemoth. If that happens so that Meta can prioritize closed-source models, it would mark a major philosophical change for the company.

While Meta deploys more advanced closed-source models internally, like those powering its Meta AI

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assistant, Zuckerberg had made [open source](#) a central part of the company's external AI strategy — a way to keep AI development moving faster. He loudly positioned the [Llama family's](#) openness as a differentiator from competitors like OpenAI, which Zuckerberg [publicly criticized](#) for becoming more closed after partnering with Microsoft. But Meta is under pressure to monetize beyond ads as it pours billions into AI.

That includes paying massive signing bonuses and nine-figure salaries to poach top researchers, building out new data centers, and covering the enormous costs of developing artificial general intelligence (AGI), or “superintelligence.”

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Despite having one of the top AI research labs in the world, Meta still lags behind rivals like OpenAI, Anthropic, Google DeepMind, and xAI when it comes to commercializing its AI work.

If Meta prioritizes closed models, it could suggest that openness was a strategic play, not an

ideological one. Past comments from Zuckerberg hint at an ambivalence toward committing to open sourcing Meta's models. On a [podcast](#) last summer, he said:

We're obviously very pro open source, but I haven't committed to releasing every single thing that we do. I'm basically very inclined to think that open sourcing is going to be good for the community and also good for us because we'll benefit from the innovations. If at some point, however, there's some qualitative change in what the thing is capable of, and we feel like it's not responsible to open source it, then we won't. It's all very difficult to predict.

Closed models would give Meta more control and more ways to monetize — especially if it believes the talent it has acquired can deliver competitive, best-in-class performance.

Such a shift could also reshape the AI landscape. Open source momentum, largely driven by Meta and models like Llama, could slow, even as OpenAI gears up to release its [still-delayed open model](#). Power could swing back toward the major players with closed ecosystems, while open source development might remain a product of grassroots efforts. The ripple effects would continue across the startup ecosystem, especially for smaller companies focused on fine-tuning, safety, and model alignment that rely on access to open foundation models.

On the world stage, Meta's retreat from open source could potentially cede ground to China, which has embraced open source AI — like DeepSeek and [Moonshot AI](#) — as a way to build domestic capability and global influence.



Rebecca Bellan

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Zuckerberg signals Meta won’t open source all of its ‘superintelligence’ AI models

Rebecca Bellan — 10:56 AM PDT · July 30, 2025

Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg shared his [vision](#) on Wednesday for “personal superintelligence,” the idea that people should be able to use AI to achieve their personal goals.

Smuggled into the letter is a signal that Meta is shifting how it plans to release AI models as it pursues “superintelligence.”

“We believe the benefits of superintelligence should be shared with the world as broadly as possible,” wrote Zuckerberg. “That said, superintelligence will raise novel safety concerns. We’ll need to be rigorous about mitigating these risks and careful about what we choose to open source.”

That wording about open source is significant. Zuckerberg has historically positioned Meta’s Llama family of open models as the company’s key differentiator from competitors like OpenAI, xAI, and Google DeepMind. Meta’s goal has been to create open AI models that were as good as or better than those closed models. In a [2024 letter](#), Zuckerberg wrote, “Starting next year, we expect future Llama models to become the most advanced in the industry.”

Zuckerberg has previously left himself room to maneuver on this commitment. “If at some point however there’s some qualitative change in what the thing is capable of, and we feel like it’s not responsible to open source it, then we won’t,” he said in a [podcast](#) last year.

And while many say Llama doesn’t fit the strict definition of open source AI — partly because Meta hasn’t released its massive training datasets — Zuckerberg’s words point to a possible change in priority: Open source may no longer be the default for Meta’s cutting-edge AI.

There's a reason why Meta's rivals keep their models closed. Closed models give companies more control over monetizing their products. Zuckerberg pointed out last year that Meta's business isn't reliant on selling access to AI models, so "releasing Llama doesn't undercut our revenue, sustainability, or ability to invest in research like it does for closed providers." Meta, of course, makes most of its money from selling internet advertising.



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Still, that stated viewpoint on open models was *before* Meta started to feel like it was falling behind competitors, and executives became obsessed with beating OpenAI's GPT-4 model while developing Llama 3.

Cut to June 2025, when Meta began its public AGI sprint in earnest by investing \$14.3 billion in Scale AI, acquiring Scale's founder and CEO, and restructuring its AI efforts under a new unit called Meta Superintelligence Labs. Meta has spent

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[billions of dollars](#) to acquire researchers and engineers from top AI firms and build out new data centers.

[Recent reports indicate](#) that all that investment has led Meta to pause testing on its latest Llama model, Behemoth, and instead focus efforts on developing a closed model.

With Zuckerberg’s mission for introducing “personal superintelligence” to the world — a decided shift from the rivals he says are working on “automating all valuable work” — his AI monetization strategy is taking shape. It’s clear from Zuckerberg’s words today that Meta plans to deliver “personal superintelligence” through its own products like augmented reality glasses and virtual reality headsets.

“Personal devices like glasses that understand our context because they can see what we see, hear what we hear, and interact with us throughout the day will become our primary computing devices,” Zuckerberg wrote in Wednesday’s letter.

When asked about Meta potentially keeping its most advanced models closed, a Meta spokesperson said that the company remains committed to open source AI and said it also expects to train closed source models in the future.

“Our position on open source AI is unchanged,” a spokesperson said. “We plan to continue releasing leading open source models. We haven’t released everything we’ve developed historically and we expect to continue training a mix of open and closed models going forward.”

This article was updated with more information about Mark Zuckerberg’s stance on open AI models.

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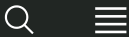
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Meta has [announced](#) the newest addition to its [Llama](#) family of generative AI models: Llama 3.3 70B.

In a [post](#) on X, Ahmad Al-Dahle, VP of generative AI at Meta, said that the text-only Llama 3.3 70B delivers the performance of Meta's largest Llama model, [Llama 3.1 405B](#), at lower cost.

"By leveraging the latest advancements in post-training techniques ... this model improves core performance at a significantly lower cost," Al-Dahle wrote.

Al-Dahle published a chart showing Llama 3.3 70B outperforming Google's Gemini 1.5 Pro, OpenAI's GPT-4o, and Amazon's newly released Nova Pro on a number of industry benchmarks, including MMLU, which evaluates a model's ability to understand language. Via email, a Meta spokesperson said that the model should deliver improvements in areas like math, general knowledge, instruction following, and app use.

Introducing Llama 3.3 — a new 70B model that delivers the performance of our 405B model but is easier & more cost-efficient to run. By leveraging the latest advancements in post-training techniques including online preference optimization, this model improves core performance at... pic.twitter.com/6oQ7b3Yuzc

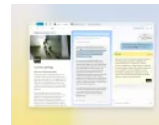
— Ahmad Al-Dahle (@Ahmad_AI_Dahle)
[December 6, 2024](#)

Llama 3.3 70B, which is available for [download](#) from the AI dev platform Hugging Face and other sources, including the official Llama [website](#), is Meta's latest play to dominate the AI field with "open" models that can be used and commercialized for a range of applications.

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Meta's terms [constrain](#) how certain developers can use Llama models; platforms with more than 700 million monthly users must request a special license. But for many, it's immaterial that Llama models aren't "[open](#)" in the strictest sense. Case in point, Llama has racked up more than 650 million downloads, according to Meta.



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Meta has leveraged Llama internally as well. [Meta AI](#), the company's AI assistant, which is powered entirely by Llama models, now has nearly 600 million monthly active users, [per](#) Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg. Zuckerberg claims that Meta AI is on track to be the most-used AI assistant in the world.

For Meta, the open nature of Llama has been a blessing and a curse. In November, a [report](#) alleged that Chinese military researchers had used a Llama model to develop a defense chatbot. Meta responded by making its Llama models [available to U.S. defense contractors](#).

Meta has also voiced concerns about its ability to comply with [the AI Act](#), the EU law that establishes a regulatory framework for AI, calling the law's implementation "too unpredictable" for its open release strategy. A related issue for the company are provisions in the GDPR, the EU's privacy law, pertaining to AI training. Meta trains AI models on the public data of Instagram and Facebook users who haven't opted out — data that in Europe is subject to GDPR guarantees.

EU regulators earlier this year requested that Meta halt training on European user data while they assessed the company's GDPR compliance. Meta relented, while at the same time endorsing an [open letter](#) calling for "a modern interpretation" of GDPR that doesn't "reject progress."

Meta, not immune to the technical challenges other AI labs are [encountering](#), is ramping up its computing infrastructure to train and serve future generations of Llama. The company announced Wednesday that it would build a \$10 billion AI data center in Louisiana — the largest AI data center Meta has ever built.

Zuckerberg [said](#) on Meta's Q4 earnings call in August that to train the next major set of Llama models, Llama 4, the company will need 10x more compute than what was needed to train Llama 3. Meta has procured a cluster of more than 100,000 Nvidia GPUs for model development, rivaling the resources of competition like xAI.

Training generative AI models is a costly business. Meta's capital expenditures rose nearly 33% to \$8.5 billion in Q2 2024, up from \$6.4 billion a year earlier, driven by investments in servers, data centers, and network infrastructure.

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Kyle Wiggers was TechCrunch’s AI Editor until June 2025. His writing has appeared in VentureBeat and Digital...

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Meta’s LlamaCon was all about undercutting OpenAI

Maxwell Zeff — 5:15 PM PDT · April 29, 2025

On Tuesday, Meta held its first ever AI developer conference, LlamaCon, at its Menlo Park, California, headquarters. The company announced the [launch of a consumer-facing Meta AI chatbot app](#), which will compete with ChatGPT, as well as a [developer-facing API](#) for accessing Llama models in the cloud.

Both releases aim to expand adoption of the company's open Llama AI models, but that goal may be secondary to Meta's true motive: beating OpenAI. Meta's AI ambition, in broad strokes, is fueling a thriving open AI ecosystem that sticks it to "closed" AI providers like OpenAI, which gate their models behind services.

Meta's AI chatbot app feels almost like a preemption of [OpenAI's rumored social network](#). It has a social feed where users can share their AI chats and offers personalized responses based on a user's Meta app activity.

As for the Llama API, it's a challenge to OpenAI's API business. The Llama API is designed to make it simpler for developers to build apps that connect to Llama models in the cloud, using just a single line of code. It eliminates the need to rely on third-party cloud providers to run Llama models and allows Meta to offer a fuller array of tools for AI developers.

Meta, like many AI companies, perceives OpenAI to be a top rival. Court filings in a case against Meta reveal that the company's execs [previously obsessed](#) over beating OpenAI's GPT-4, which was once a state-of-the-art model. Undercutting proprietary AI model providers like OpenAI has long been core to Meta's AI strategy. In a [July 2024 letter](#), Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg sought to contrast Meta with companies like OpenAI, writing that "selling access to AI models isn't [Meta's] business model."

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Several AI researchers who spoke with TechCrunch ahead of LlamaCon were hoping Meta would [release a competitive AI reasoning model like OpenAI's o3-mini](#). The company didn't end up doing so. But for Meta, it's not necessarily about winning the AI race.

During an onstage conversation with Databricks CEO Ali Ghodsi during LlamaCon, Zuckerberg said he sees any AI lab that makes its models openly available, including DeepSeek and Alibaba's Qwen, as allies in the fight against closed model providers.



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“Part of the value around open source is that you can mix and match. So if another model, like DeepSeek, is better — or if Qwen is better at something — then, as developers, you have the ability to take the best parts of the intelligence from different models and produce exactly what you need,” said Zuckerberg. “This is part of how I think open source basically passes in quality all the

closed source [models] ... [I]t feels like sort of an unstoppable force.”

Beyond stunting OpenAI’s growth, Meta may also be trying to push its open models [to satisfy a regulatory carveout](#). The EU AI Act grants special privileges to companies that distribute “free and open source” AI systems. Meta often claims its Llama models are “open source,” [despite disagreement on whether they meet the necessary criteria](#).

Regardless of the reason, Meta seems content to kick off AI launches that strengthen the open model ecosystem and limit OpenAI’s growth — sometimes at the expense of failing to deliver cutting-edge models itself.

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